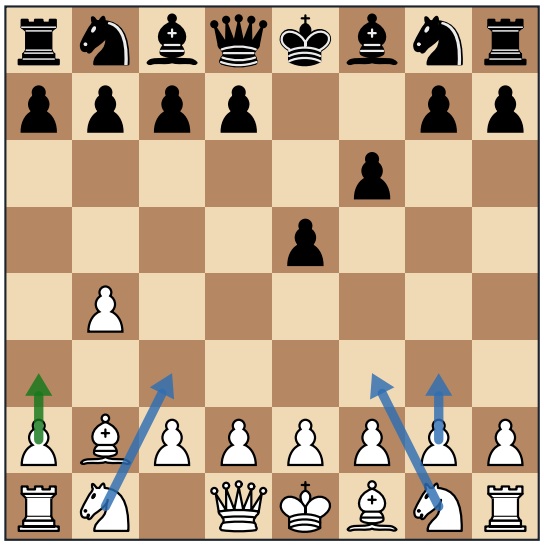
Polish Opening

ECO A00-A05 | 25 named lines | Flank openings (English, Reti, Bird, KIA)

In one sentence: Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Memory pattern: Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.



Main line: 1.b4 e5 2.Bb2 f6

Key ideas

1. Control d5 and e5 with pawns on c4 and pieces on f3 and c3.
2. Fianchetto the king's bishop (g3, Bg2) for long-diagonal pressure.
3. Choose a center after seeing Black's setup: d4 or e4.
4. Transpose to Queen's Gambit, Catalan or Sicilian-style structures.
5. English: reversed Sicilian ideas with extra tempo.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **-0.13** (equal, depth 17). Best: a3.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle short; g3/Bg2 is a safe shelter.
3. Best minor pieces?	Bg2 and Bb2 on the long diagonals, knights c3/f3, breaks with d4/e4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

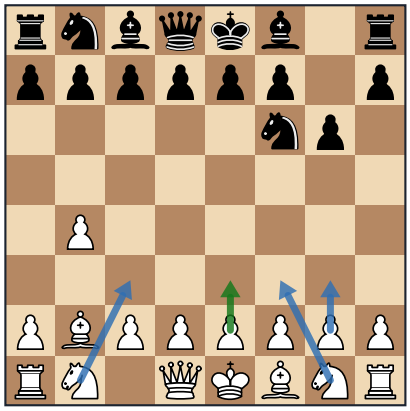
The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.b4 e5 2.Bb2 f6

Move	Why it is played
1. b4	Queenside expansion. Gains space on the wing.
1... e5	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. Bb2	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
2... f6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

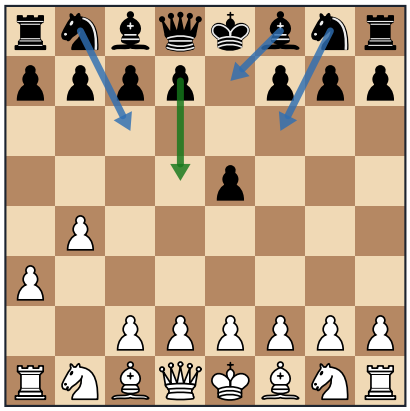


Position after the line

King's Indian Variation A00 | 3 lines

`1.b4 Nf6 2.Bb2 g6`

Stockfish: **+0.13** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: e3.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)
Sub-variations: Schiffler Attack, Sokolsky Attack

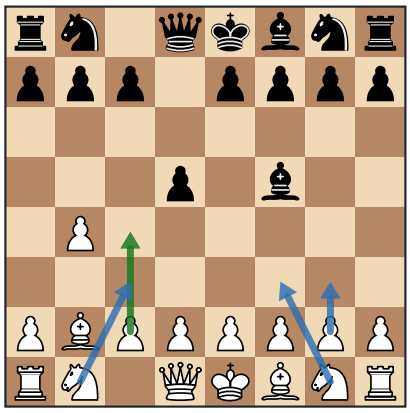


Position after the line

Bugayev Attack A00 | 1 lines

`1.b4 e5 2.a3`

Stockfish: **-0.34** (slightly better for Black, depth 17). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

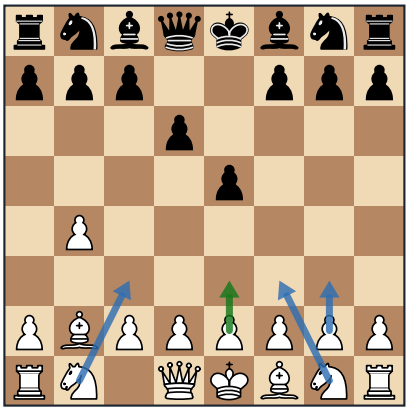


Position after the line

Baltic Defense A00 | 1 lines

`1.b4 d5 2.Bb2 Bf5`

Stockfish: **-0.22** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: c4.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)

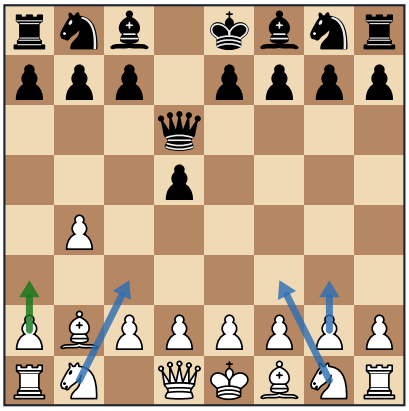


Position after the line

Czech Defense A00 | 1 lines

`1.b4 e5 2.Bb2 d6`

Stockfish: **+0.16** (equal, depth 18). Best next move: e3.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)

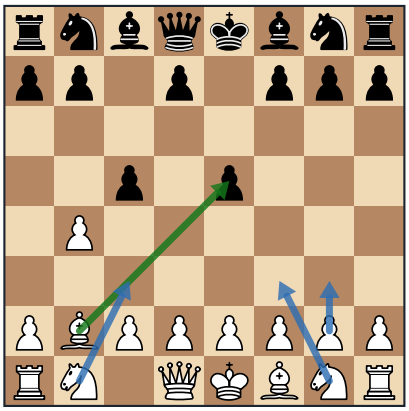


Position after the line

German Defense A00 | 1 lines

`1.b4 d5 2.Bb2 Qd6`

Stockfish: **+0.05** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: a3.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)



Position after the line

Wolferts Gambit A00 | 1 lines

`1.b4 e5 2.Bb2 c5`

Stockfish: **+0.12** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: Bxe5.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Flank openings are about flexibility, not speed. Make sure you know the main transpositions and what structures you want, then choose moves accordingly.

Why play it

Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Typical mistakes

- Being too passive and letting Black take the center for free.
- Playing d3 and e4 without a plan for the queenside pawns.
- Neglecting development while chasing a fianchetto.

Typical tactics and traps

- Early Qb3 or Qa4 pins that win the c4 or d5 pawn if Black is careless.
- Tactics on the long diagonal against b7/g7.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Balanced, flexible endgames with minor advantages for the better-placed bishops.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Polish Opening (all lines)** — A00
  `1.b4`
  - **Birmingham Gambit** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...c5`
  - **Dutch Defense** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...f5`
  - **Grigorian Variation** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...Nc6`
  - **Karniewski Variation** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...Nh6`
  - **Outflank Variation** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...c6`
    - **Schuehler Gambit** — A00
      `1.b4 c6 -> 2.Bb2 a5 3.b5`
  - **Symmetrical Variation** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...b5`
  - **Bugayev Attack** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...e5 2.a3`
  - **Baltic Defense** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...d5 2.Bb2 Bf5`
  - **Czech Defense** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...e5 2.Bb2 d6`
  - **German Defense** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...d5 2.Bb2 Qd6`
  - **King's Indian Variation** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...Nf6 2.Bb2 g6`
    - **Schiffler Attack** — A00
      `1.b4 Nf6 2.Bb2 g6 -> 3.e4`
    - **Sokolsky Attack** — A00
      `1.b4 Nf6 2.Bb2 g6 -> 3.c4 Bg7 4.e3 d6 5.Nf3 O-O 6.d4`
  - **Wolferts Gambit** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...e5 2.Bb2 c5`
  - **Bugayev Advance Variation** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...e5 2.Bb2 f6 3.b5`
  - **Myers Variation** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...d5 2.Bb2 c6 3.a4`
  - **Tartakower Gambit** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...e5 2.Bb2 f6 3.e4`
  - **Zukertort System** — A05
    `1.Nf3 Nf6 2.b4 g6 3.Bb2`
  - **Queen's Indian Variation** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...e6 2.Bb2 Nf6 3.b5 b6`
  - **Queenside Defense** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...e6 2.Bb2 Nf6 3.b5 a6`
  - **Schiffler-Sokolsky Variation** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...e6 2.Bb2 Nf6 3.b5 d5 4.e3`
  - **Schuehler Gambit** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...c6 2.Bb2 a5 3.b5 cxb5 4.e4`
  - **Rooks Swap Line** — A00
    `1.b4 -> 1...e6 2.Bb2 Nf6 3.b5 a6 4.a4 axb5 5.axb5 Rxa1 6.Bxa1`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.b4 e5 2.Bb2 f6
```

Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nf3 -> g3 -> Bg2 -> O-O
Black	e5 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> c5 -> g6

Three rules to remember

1. Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.
2. Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.
3. White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

Pawn structure in one line

Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.